Jesus Christ'. While largely tolerant towards idolaters, particularly those with a developed material culture, he betrays a garden-variety prejudice against Muslims, best assessed in light of a post-Crusades Christendom. For instance, he deems Christians 'far more valiant than Saracens'. Taking sides in a conflict, he declares that 'it is not fitting that Saracen dogs should lord it over Christians'. But these and other expressions of contempt—the 'quite repulsive' women of Zanzibar, Tartars who live like 'brute beasts' because they smear food on the mouth of their gods, Indians being 'paltry creatures and mean spirited'—are vastly outnumbered by expressions of admiration, fair-mindedness and wonder. He likely had no role models in his writing and the result such as it is, warts and all, is nothing short of enthralling.

Marco Polo spent many months, perhaps the better part of a year, in India. Barring a few cursory mentions of inland areas, his account of India is limited to the coastal belt and ends with this tantalizing remark, 'Of the inland regions I have told you nothing; for the tale will be too long in the telling.' We would have happily read on, Marco.